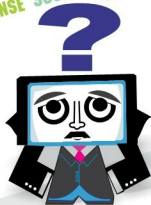


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experiments on virtual simulations on computer," informs Ashutosh Agarwal, general manager, Tesca Technologies. Also, there is trend towards hardware and software interfacing of the trainer kits.

"Training solutions giving total coverage for topics like embedded systems, instrumentation, process control, remote data acquisition, mechatronics, advanced communication, VLSI and DSP are in demand. These demands are market-driven as the industry is looking for workforce trained in these technologies to cut-short their in-company training requirements," says Joshi.

In robotic kits, programmable robots are the most popular. These kits come with sensors, motors and a robot brain. One can connect the sensors to the brain according to one's application and program the brain to perform different kinds of behaviours. These

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Open Source platform is becoming popular as it has tremendous online support and a huge user community—
Siddharth Dev, chief technology officer, Technido

kits are available for schools as well as colleges with a proportional level of complexity.

Each robotic kit features either pre-assembled or unassembled PC boards, hardware and mechanical drive. Only basic hand tools are required for assembly. These fascinating robotic kits allow one to experience and learn any of the features like sound sensor, remote control, infrared sensor, wired control and/or programmable memory.

"Reconfigurable kits are in demand. Customers prefer to invest once and afterwards they want their machines to be easily modified or programmed with smaller or zero investment. Also, users choose kits that come with proper manuals and



Scientech's ST2358 blood pressure measurement trainer

support. In this context, Open Source platform is becoming popular as it has tremendous online support and a huge user community," says Siddharth Dev, chief technology officer, Technido.

Opportunities ahead

"There is more scope for Open Source hardware and software," says Chetanya Sahu, chief marketing officer, Thinnware (a venture of KC Robotics & Embedded).

In Dec. 2006 issue of *Scientific American*, Bill Gates drew parallels between the PC industry in its early days and the fledgling robotics industry today. He noted that robotics companies had no standard operating software that would let popular applications run on a variety of machines. There was practically no standardisation on the hardware side either.

"Whenever somebody wants to build a new robot, he usually has to start from square one," Gates wrote.

However, among different kits, "the future for robotic kits, in particular, seems to be endless. There are numerous ways in which the industry can work upon them. The most common approach is to make them more humanoid and interactive. Another approach is to make them more animalistic like pets," says Mitesh Patel, chief executive officer, AMP TRONICS.

"Robotics is no longer just a hobby. Students are becoming serious and want career-oriented training,"